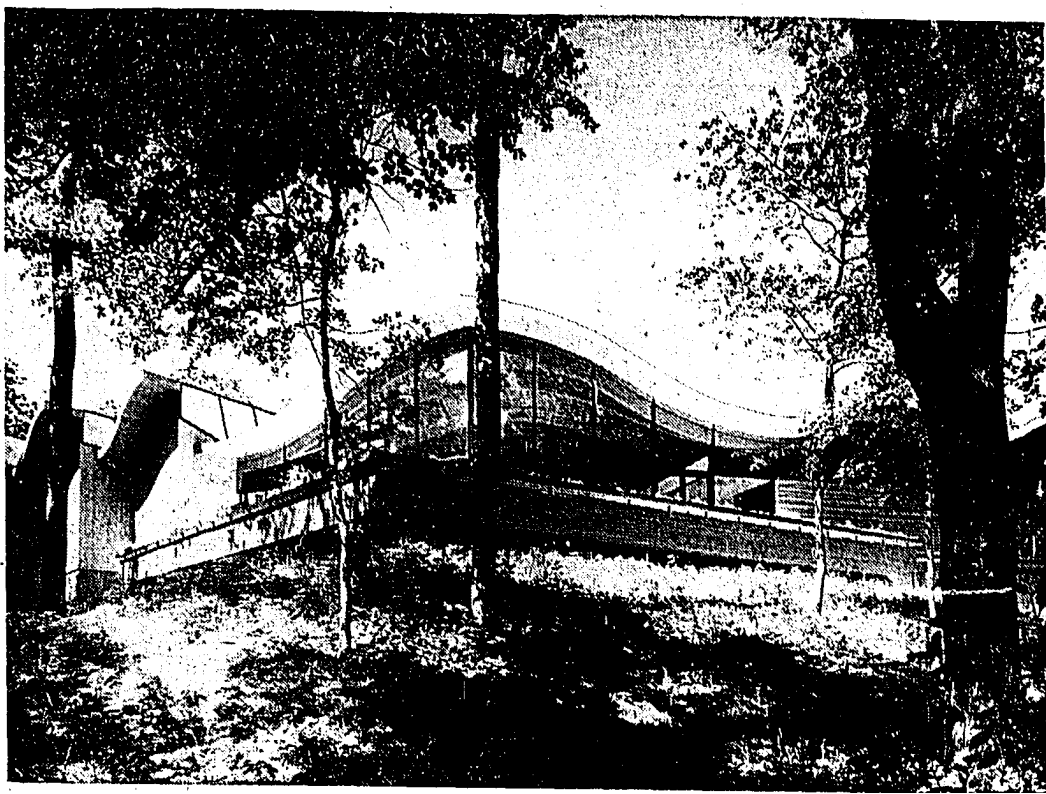




Duxbury Art Complex by Richard O. Abbott, a setting scaled to its contents, surroundings and visitors.
(Architecture Plus photo)

Museum gamesmanship

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

The news that the Boston Museum of Fine Arts (FMA) had been thinking of spending a lot of money to demolish the building's grand staircase raises a lot of issues about the architecture of museums.

The staircase has got to go, says the anti-staircase lobby, because "modern man does not like to see a grand staircase" and because getting rid of it will make the museum less confusing.

Confusing it certainly is. In fact, I have never visited this building's trackless wastes without experiencing instant fatigue, often before I even see the staircase. Normally, the high points of any visit are the cafeteria and the bookstore, the only places where you have much sense of involvement with the materials at hand. The cafeteria offers the added relief of being the only place from which you can see outside.

The grand staircase isn't the problem. The problem is that the MFA is too big (both in extent and in scale) and too much like too many other museums.

To a layman, it seems that all the big metropolitan art museums are in some kind of competition to become as much like each other as possible. Each seems to want the same ideally balanced collection, a kind of aesthetic smorgasbord consisting of one or two pictures by every artist in every period since time began. Walking into the MFA, or the National Gallery, or the Metropolitan in New York, is like walking into a supermarket in a strange city and knowing that you'll see the same national brand names.

Wanting to be all alike, they all grow the same paintings, driving

prices to nutty levels for the few superstars they themselves have created, ignoring the other 99.9 percent of artists, many equally good, all for the sake of ending up with an unrelated international sampler of work that has no particular connection with the cultural history of the city or the particular physical setting provided by the architecture of the museum itself.

So far as possible, these objects are then displayed in a vacuum. Whatever architectural character the building may have is typically subverted by the curator of displays in favor of off-white walls and shadowless light, like a dentist's office.

Architecturally, museums seem to work best when they are not too big, when there is some coherence to the collection, and when there is some relationship between the building and its contents, and between the building and the city. Who can forget the Uffizi in Florence, that small, poorly balanced collection of Italian Renaissance paintings in an Italian Renaissance palace? Or the Louisa in Denmark, as open and modern in its architecture as it is in its collection?

For the cost of demolishing that one staircase, the syndics of the MFA could build a whole new satellite museum in some town, or maybe renovate a characteristic Boston warehouse or church into a museum of the art of the city.

It is encouraging to see the Center for the Arts grappling to accommodate itself to its new home in a flower market and movie theater, and the Institute of Contemporary Arts

moving into an abandoned police station. One hopes that these buildings' individuality will not be sacrificed for a false ideal of purity in display.

In an age when people travel so much, perhaps there is less need for the big department store museums that try to contain a representative slice of everything, certainly there has been a recent growth in smaller local museums. Shown here, by way of contrast, is the most recent of these, the Duxbury Art Complex designed by Richard O. Abbott.

This building manages to convey a sense of place that few of the big museums have. It does this despite some curious and even ludicrous drawbacks.

Financed by the Weyerhaeuser family, heirs to a lumber fortune, the building appears at first glance to be a kind of sales mockup of all the things you can do with wood.

The Weyerhaeusers asked the architect for a "monument to wood" and they certainly got it. Laminated beams, both curving and straight, swirl overhead and meet at odd angles, while the exterior features textured siding in a choice of horizontal or vertical. All these materials come together at the joints in a manner reminiscent of Chinese puzzles.

Yet, despite its shortcomings, the building sits well on a beautiful site, backed by a wooded hollow with a stream, providing a setting for art that seems appropriately scaled to its contents, to its surroundings, and to the human beings who visit it. These are qualities no amount of grandeur, staired or stairless, can replace.